PRODUCT CASE STUDY

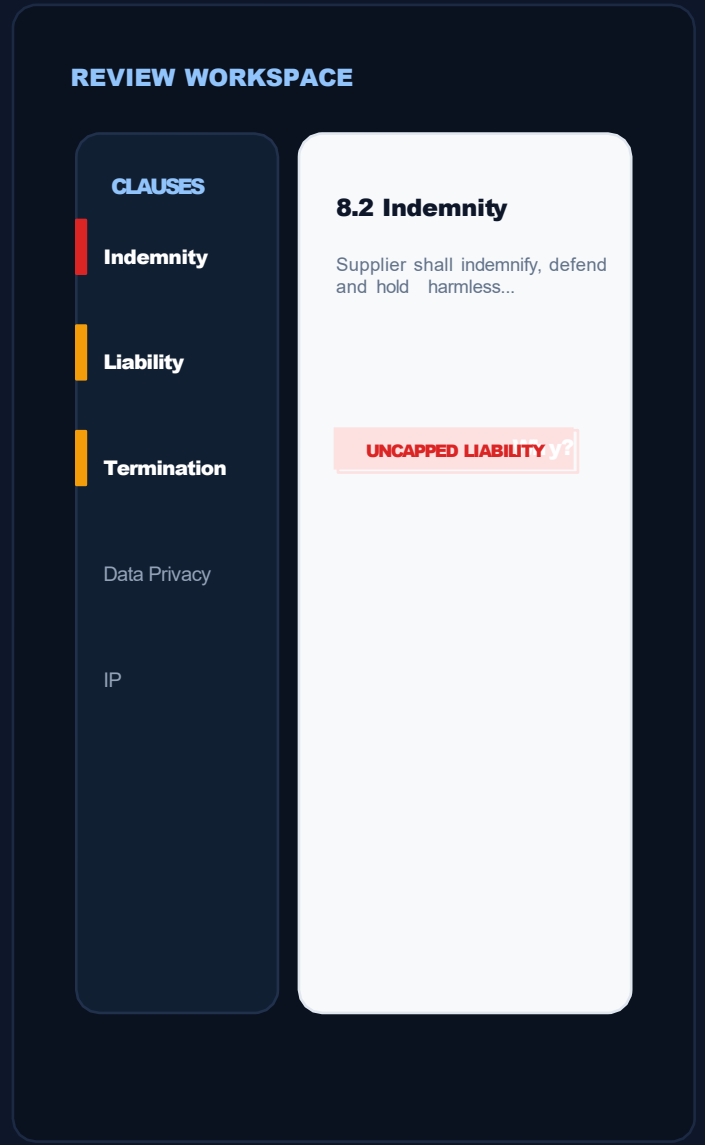
AI Contract Review Copilot

A web-based legal decision-support workspace for faster, safer first-pass review of commercial contracts.

North-star idea

Compress “read the whole contract” into “know what deserves my attention first.”

MVP focus — MSAs — Desktop web app — Human-in-the-loop



Ajay Mahadik • September 2026

01 | Summary & Problem

The product is designed around a simple tension: **review faster without losing legal judgment**.

PROBLEM STATEMENT

In-house commercial lawyers spend substantial time on repetitive first-pass contract review, particularly identifying deviations from company-approved positions. This creates review bottlenecks and limits the time lawyers can spend on higher-value negotiation and risk assessment. However, any productivity improvement must not come at the expense of missing material contractual risks.

PROBLEM ANALYSIS

Target user

In-house commercial lawyers / legal teams

Pain

Time-consuming, repetitive first-pass review

Business impact

Longer contract turnaround → slower business operations

User impact

Less time for negotiation and high-value legal work

Opportunity

Reduce manual review effort without compromising legal accuracy or lawyer control

Core product question → How might we help lawyers identify what deserves attention first, explain why, and act without giving up the final legal decision?

02 | Problem & Evidence

Evidence is treated as something to validate—not something to manufacture for the portfolio.

WORKING PROBLEM SIGNALS

1. **Repetitive review** — Clause-by-clause comparison to standard positions consumes lawyer attention.
2. **Scattered context** — Playbooks, prior agreements, comments and business context can live in different places.
3. **Risk is not binary** — Some deviations are routine; others create material exposure. Lawyers need prioritization, not just highlighting.
4. **Unknown risks exist** — A playbook cannot cover every possible clause or business situation.

DISCOVERY / BASELINE PLAN

8-10	lawyers shadowed across commercial review workflows
80–100	MSAs annotated to create a benchmark risk set
Baseline	time from review start →first-pass completion
Quality	critical-risk misses, useful findings, false positives
Workflow	where playbook comparison or context lookup slows review

Portfolio note: all metric targets below are proposed launch hypotheses.

This framing deliberately avoids invented market statistics; the first PM task is to validate the magnitude and shape of the pain with real legal teams.

03 | Customers & Jobs-to-be-Done

The MVP (Minimum Viable Product) is intentionally centered on one primary user: the lawyer making the review decision.

PERSONA TABLE

Persona	Role	Primary goal	Pain / friction	Needs	MVP?
In-house commercial lawyer	Reviews contracts before signature	Surface material issues and reach a decision quickly	Manual comparison; context switching; review fatigue	Traceability, prioritization, control	PRIMARY
Business requester / deal owner	Owns the deal or vendor process	Get to signature without avoidable legal delay	Unclear status; back-and-forth	Clear next step, status, ETA	SECONDARY
Legal ops / team manager	Improves legal team throughput	Increase capacity and consistency	Limited visibility into workload / bottlenecks	Reporting, standardization, adoption	SECONDARY

CORE JTBD

"When I receive a contract that needs legal review, I want to quickly identify material deviations and other potential risks, understand why they matter, and decide what to do next—so I can focus my time on issues that genuinely require legal judgment."

04 | Goals & Success Metrics

Optimize for faster first-pass review, but only inside a quality envelope.

DESIRED PRODUCT OUTCOME

Reduce the amount of lawyer time required for an initial contract review while maintaining high coverage of material contractual risks.

PRIMARY METRIC

Median first-pass review time

BASELINE: TBD | TARGET: -40% | INSTRUMENT: TIMESTAMPS

Review start → first-pass completion. Use median rather than average to avoid a few unusually complex contracts dominating the metric.

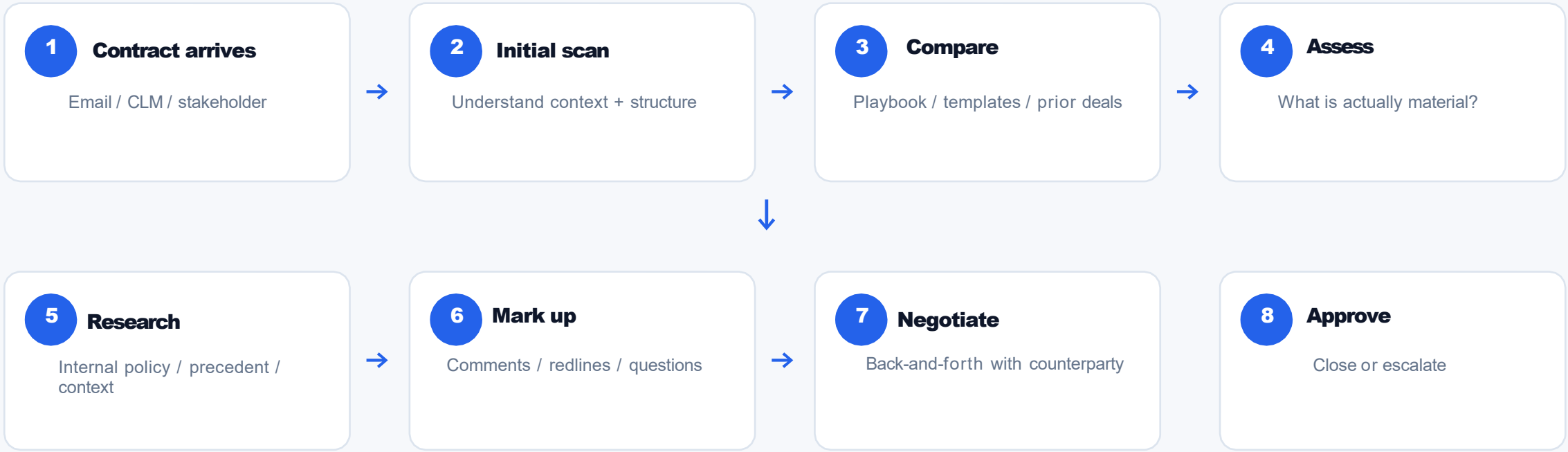
SECONDARY + GUARDRAILS

Contract turnaround	-30%	submission → legal complete
AI-assisted review coverage	≥70%	% of clauses reviewed with AI assistance
Useful finding rate	≥60%	lawyer labels finding useful / actionable
Critical-risk recall	≥98%	benchmark recall on critical findings
Material-risk recall	≥95%	benchmark recall across material findings
False-positive rate	≤40%	flagged findings judged non-actionable

Launch thresholds are proposed product hypotheses; validate them against a legal benchmark and real workflow baseline before committing engineering capacity.

05 | Current-State Workflow

The opportunity appears where review work repeatedly asks the lawyer to search, compare, interpret, and re-check.



Main opportunity areas → clause finding • playbook comparison • risk prioritization • evidence retrieval • repeat-review memory

06 | Scope & Non-goals

A narrow MVP gives us a testable wedge instead of an unrealistic “AI lawyer.”

IN SCOPE FOR V1

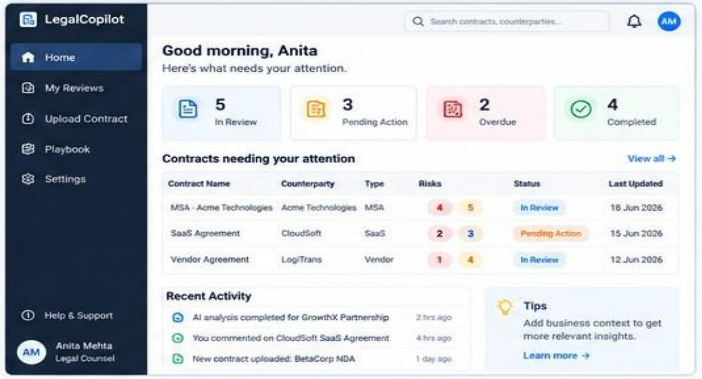
Contract family	Master Services Agreements (MSAs)
Inputs	PDF / DOCX + optional business context
Known-risk detection	Compare against structured company playbook
Unknown-risk detection	Surface potential material risks not explicitly covered
Explainability	Clause-level evidence, playbook reference, rationale
Action support	Comments, suggested fallback language, redline review, escalate
Workspace	Desktop web app with clause navigator + contract + AI panel
Review memory	Track revisions and preserve prior findings

EXPLICIT NON-GOALS

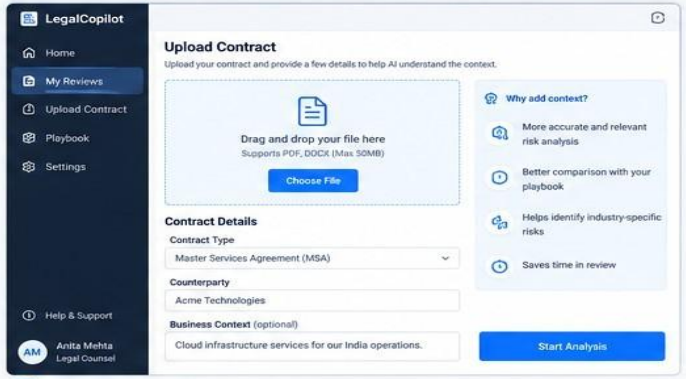
Autonomous legal approval	Lawyer remains accountable for final decision.
Autonomous negotiation	No AI-to-counterparty negotiation in V1.
All contract types	Expand only after MSA workflow proves value.
Every possible legal risk	Coverage grows through benchmark + feedback loops.
Generic business chatbot	Product is a review workspace, not open-ended legal advice.
Mobile-first experience	Primary workflow requires desktop document review.

07 | Solution Sketch & UX

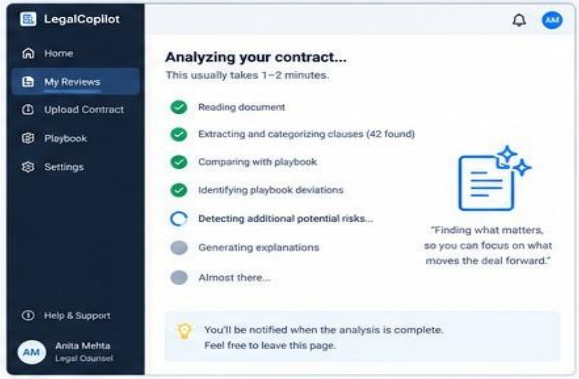
The product is a web workspace that turns a long contract into a prioritized review queue.



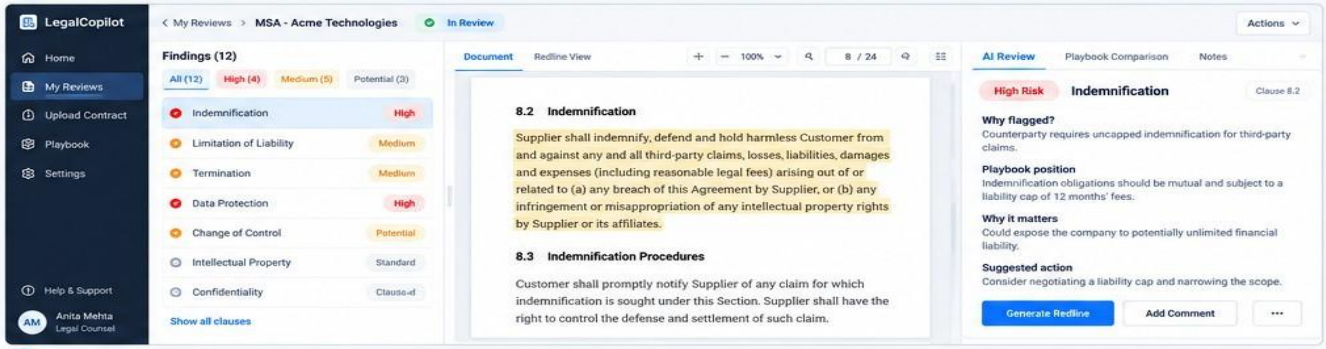
1 **Dashboard** – Overview of contracts and pending actions



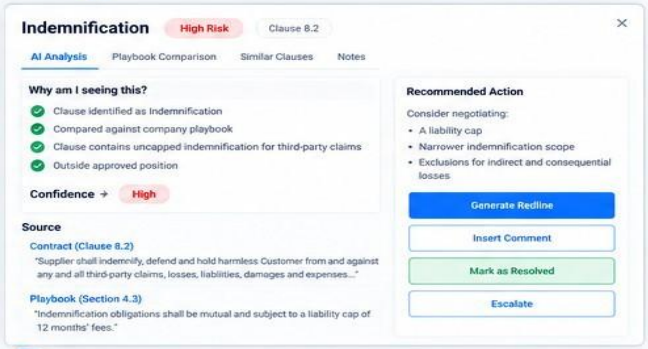
2 **Upload Contract** – Add key details



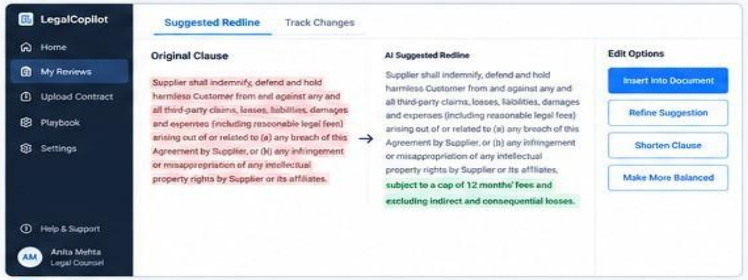
3 **AI Analysis** – Real-time progress



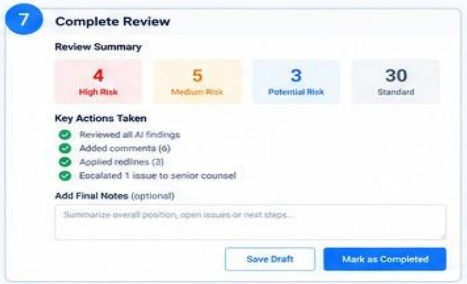
4 **Contract Review Workspace** – Document, clause list and AI findings



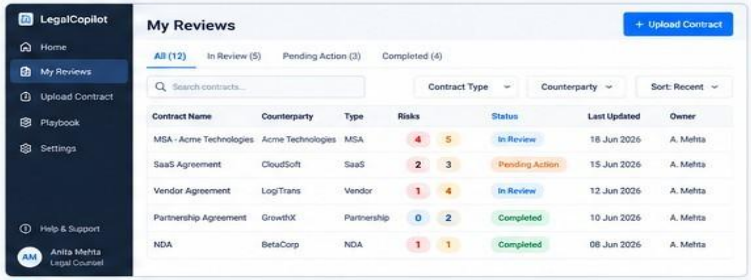
5 **Clause Detail** – Explanation, playbook comparison and actions



6 **AI Suggested Redline** – Review and edit



7 **Complete Review** – Summary and close out



8 **My Reviews** – Track Progress

CORE UX PRINCIPLES

1. Show what matters first
2. Keep original clause visible
3. Separate confidence from severity
4. Explain every AI finding
5. **Let the lawyer decide**
6. Make revisions first-class

Decision remains with lawyer

Desktop-first because the workflow depends on side-by-side document reading, clause navigation, comparison and redlining.

08 | Core Review Workspace

The centerpiece is a split-pane review experience: clause map + source document + AI reasoning.

← My Reviews / MSA – Acme Technologies IN REVIEW Actions ▾

CLAUSES

- Indemnification HIGH
- Limitation of Liability MED
- Termination MED
- Data Protection HIGH
- Confidentiality
- Intellectual Property

8.2 Indemnification

Supplier shall indemnify, defend and hold harmless Customer from and against any and all third-party claims, losses, liabilities, damages, costs and expenses...

UNCAPPED INDEMNIFICATION

...

AI REVIEW HIGH RISK

Why was this flagged?

Counterparty requires uncapped indemnification for third-party claims.

Playbook position

Liability generally capped at 12 months' fees.

Why it matters

Could expose the company to potentially unlimited financial liability.

Recommended action

Consider negotiating a cap and narrower indemnification scope.

Generate Redline Add Comment Escalate

09 | AI Risk Scoring & Prioritization

The model should not produce one opaque “contract score”; it should produce explainable findings.



User-facing principle: risk severity and model confidence are separate dimensions. High-impact / lower-confidence findings should remain visible as “Potential Risk — Needs Review.”

10 | Risk Model, Decision Rules & Guardrails

Severity answers “how serious?”; confidence answers “how sure are we?” — the UI shows both concepts without exposing a fake precision score.

RISK PIPELINE

1. **Extract** — structure + clauses
2. **Classify** — legal category
3. **Compare** — playbook or no playbook
4. **Assess** — impact + likelihood + evidence
5. **Classify** — High / Medium / Potential / Standard
6. **Prioritize** — importance + business context

DECISION RULES

Playbook deviation	Clear mismatch with an approved position → stronger classification if impact is material.
Potential material risk	Issue not covered by playbook, but evidence suggests meaningful legal / financial / operational impact.
High impact + low confidence	Never silently downgrade; surface as Potential Risk — Needs Review
Evidence required	Every finding links to the source clause and, where applicable, the specific playbook rule.

USER-FACING CATEGORIES

High Risk	Material deviation or high-impact risk
Medium Risk	Moderate deviation or potential risk
Potential Risk	Not in playbook but may be material
Standard	No material issue detected

11 | PRD at a Glance

A compact view of the product decisions this case study commits to.

User	**In-house commercial lawyer**	**Outcome**	**↓ first-pass review time**
Contract focus	Master Services Agreements	**Quality guardrail**	**critical-risk recall ≥98%**
Experience	Desktop web / split-pane workspace	**AI risk model**	severity + confidence + evidence
Core value	Prioritized, explainable review support	**MVP shape**	8–10 risk categories + uncovered-risk detection
Human role	Final legal decision stays with lawyer	**Next step**	Discovery + benchmark creation + baseline timing

The product wins when lawyers spend less time hunting for issues—and more time exercising judgment where it matters.

End of PRD